



Full Price for an Empty Camp

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

On June 9, 2026, the Government Accountability Office, the nonpartisan agency that audits federal spending for Congress, released a report detailing waste and safety failures at Camp East Montana, the nation's largest immigration detention facility. The following is a guest commentary published in a national newspaper, in which the writer addresses fellow taxpayers about what the audit found.

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 On June 9 the Government Accountability Office, the agency Congress assigns to audit federal spending, published what its auditors found at Camp East Montana, the largest immigration detention facility the federal government has ever run. The camp opened in August 2025 on Fort Bliss, an Army post in El Paso, Texas, with room for 5,000 people and an operating contract worth \$1.3 billion. **That money is ours.**

[Telegraphic sentence] The auditors went to see what it bought.

2 For its first two weeks, from August 1 to August 15, 2025, the camp held no detained people at all. The Army, under terms the government itself had signed, paid the full cost anyway: **guards for no one, medical care for no one, transportation for no one, meals for no one** [Epistrophe]. Those two empty weeks cost \$11.5 million. Roughly \$423,000 more went to wasted meals between mid-August and the end of September, because the contract required full meal and service payments for 5,000 people no matter how many were actually there. **The payments always arrived in full; the people never did.** [Antithesis] At the end of February 2026, the camp built for 5,000 held about 1,600.

3 The auditors also measured the camp against the government's own detention standards and found failures the report described as "risking the safety and security of detained noncitizens and staff." **When a camp opened without perimeter security cameras, without outdoor recreation space, without anywhere for the people inside to meet a lawyer or a family member; when a loaded firearm went missing; when a man with tuberculosis was housed with the general population in November because screening procedures were not followed, and not one detainee with HIV or diabetes had a treatment plan on file, that camp was failing the one duty that justifies holding anyone at all, which is keeping the people in its custody safe.** [Anaphora] **We paid full price again. At least four people have died at Camp East Montana. The local coroner ruled one of those deaths a homicide, and the report notes that "evidence associated with the incident was missing or destroyed."** [Pathos]

4 Some of this has since moved. In April 2026, ICE, the federal agency that runs immigration detention, ended the operating contract early, a step the government may take without claiming anyone broke the rules, and chose a new contractor to run the camp. The auditors issued four recommendations, two to ICE, one to the Department of the Army, and one to the Department of Homeland Security, and estimated that tens of millions of dollars could still be saved through September 2026.

5 The report's warning reaches past El Paso. **Thirty-eight billion dollars is planned for the Department of Homeland Security to convert warehouses into new detention facilities, and the auditors warned that this**

camp's failures could become the blueprint for that spending. That is roughly thirty times the contract that just failed. [Logos] We funded the first camp without looking; we owe the next ones the attention this one never got. Ask what a contract pays for when the beds are empty. Ask who checks the standards before the buses arrive. The auditors looked once. The next look belongs to us.

Devices, and why they are here:

Telegraphic sentence (paragraph 1): "That money is ours."

A four-word claim of ownership lands flat after two long factual sentences, planting the moral stake, the public's money, before a single finding is reported.

Epistrophe (paragraph 2): "guards for no one, medical care for no one, transportation for no one, meals for no one"

Repeating "for no one" at the end of each item makes every paid-for service collapse into the same absence, so the waste is felt service by service instead of as one abstract sum.

Antithesis (paragraph 2): "The payments always arrived in full; the people never did."

Balancing "the payments always arrived in full" against "the people never did" compresses the contract's central failure, full cost for a fraction of the population, into one opposed pair.

Anaphora (paragraph 3): "When a camp opened without perimeter security cameras, without outdoor recreation space, without anywhere for the people inside to meet a lawyer or a family member; when a loaded firearm went missing; when a man with tuberculosis was housed with the general population in November because screening procedures were not followed, and not one detainee with HIV or diabetes had a treatment plan on file, that camp was failing the one duty that justifies holding anyone at all, which is keeping the people in its custody safe."

The repeated "when" clauses stack the documented failures into one accumulating runaway, withholding the verdict so it lands with their combined weight.

Pathos (paragraph 3): "At least four people have died at Camp East Montana. The local coroner ruled one of those deaths a homicide, and the report notes that "evidence associated with the incident was missing or destroyed.""

The deaths, the homicide ruling, and the destroyed evidence are stated without one emotional adjective; the bare facts carry the feeling, which reads as restraint rather than manipulation.

Logos (paragraph 5): "Thirty-eight billion dollars is planned for the Department of Homeland Security to convert warehouses into new detention facilities, and the auditors warned that this camp's failures could become the blueprint for that spending. That is roughly thirty times the contract that just failed."

The arithmetic comparison, \$38 billion against the \$1.3 billion contract, grounds the closing charge in verifiable scale rather than alarm.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the third paragraph, the writer follows the long sentence beginning "When a camp opened" with the short sentence "We paid full price again." primarily to

- A) turn the catalogue of safety failures into a shared financial complicity the reader cannot stand apart from
- B) emphasize the thoroughness of the auditors' accounting of the empty weeks
- C) concede that the camp's conditions matter less to the report than the contract's cost
- D) shift the essay from the auditors' findings to the writer's firsthand experience of the camp

2. In the second paragraph, the repetition of "for no one" in "guards for no one, medical care for no one, transportation for no one, meals for no one" serves primarily to
- A) mock the contractors who staffed the empty facility
 - B) suggest that the services were poorly delivered even when detained people were present
 - C) exaggerate the camp's emptiness beyond what the audit documents
 - D) itemize each paid-for service against the same absence so the waste is felt item by item rather than as one abstract sum

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer A. The short sentence converts the runway's safety catalogue into the essay's running ledger of collective payment, binding the "we" to the failure; that is its function after the long suspension. The option claiming conditions matter less than cost inverts the relationship the piece builds, since the paragraph treats the safety failures as the graver half of the same purchase. The option about firsthand experience imports a personal vantage the passage never contains; the writer speaks only from the report. The option about accounting thoroughness states a true feature of the essay but ties it to the wrong location, since the itemized accounting belongs to the second paragraph's empty-weeks figures, not to this sentence's effect.

2. Answer D. The repetition breaks the \$11.5 million into its component services and sets each against the identical emptiness, making the figure concrete before it is named. The option about poor delivery describes a real concern of the essay but attaches it to the wrong span; quality failures are the third paragraph's subject, while this list concerns payment with nobody present. The option about mockery names the device but assigns it an effect the tone does not support, since the passage indicts through fact and never ridicules. The option about exaggeration is over-broad: the emptiness during August 1 to 15 is the audit's documented finding, and the device counts costs rather than inflating them.

Discussion questions:

1. The writer repeatedly says "we" paid and closes by handing "the next look" to the reader. What does the piece gain, and what does it risk, by implicating its audience instead of blaming only the agencies?
2. The piece argues forcefully about waste and safety while never taking a side on immigration policy itself. Where exactly does the writer hold that line, and does the restraint make the charge stronger or weaker?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. By folding the audience into the verdict ("That money is ours," "We paid full price again"), the writer converts spectators into parties to the failure, which makes the closing charge read as a duty rather than advice. The risk is resentment: a reader who never chose the contract may reject the shared blame. The writer manages that risk by keeping the accusation factual, payments, dates, and dollar figures, so that standing apart feels like denial rather than innocence.

2. The line is held at the level of target: every charge lands on the contract's structure, the unmet standards, and the agencies as institutions, never on detention policy or any named official. The narrow target arguably strengthens the piece, because readers on either side of immigration politics can agree that paying \$11.5 million for an empty camp and losing a loaded firearm are failures; a broader target would let readers dismiss the charge as partisanship instead of answering it.

Writing prompt (AP FRQ Q3: Argument):

In "Full Price for an Empty Camp," the writer claims that responsibility for how public money is spent does not end with official watchdogs: "The auditors looked once. The next look belongs to us." Write an essay that argues your position on the extent to which ordinary citizens are responsible for overseeing how their government spends money. Use appropriate evidence from your reading, experience, or observations to develop your argument.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- This is not an argument against immigration detention or for any immigration policy; the charge targets the contract structure and the unmet safety standards. Students who read it as a side on immigration are importing a stance the text never takes.
- "For no one" is epistrophe, repetition at the END of successive phrases, not anaphora; the anaphora is the "When... when... when..." runway in paragraph 3. Students routinely conflate the two.
- The \$11.5 million and the roughly \$423,000 are separate findings: the first covers the fully empty August 1 to 15 period, the second covers meals during below-capacity operations afterward. Students tend to merge them into one figure.
- "We paid full price again." is a complete five-word sentence used as a button after the runway, not a sentence fragment.

AP exam alignment:

MCQ 1: Reasoning and Organization (Skill Category 5; CED 5.A/5.C), the function of a short sentence placed after a cumulative runway. MCQ 2: Style (Skill Category 7; CED 7.A/7.B), the effect of repetition (epistrophe). Writing: FRQ Q3 Argument, defend, challenge, or qualify a debatable claim about civic responsibility for public spending. The headnote primes Rhetorical Situation analysis (Skill Category 1): speaker role (a taxpayer writing a guest commentary), audience (fellow taxpayers), occasion (the June 9, 2026 GAO report).